



CROP ROTATION / KNOW YOUR FAMILIES

# Rotate. Record. Repeat.

Crop rotation for UK beds, allotments and containers

Move related annual crops around your growing space to reduce repeated pressure from some soil pests and diseases. A four-year cycle is a useful starting point: return in year five, after three intervening growing years.

[R1]

## Start with the plant family

| FAMILY                | COMMON CROPS                                                                           | GROUP* |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Potato family         | Potato, tomato, pepper, aubergine                                                      | A      |
| Pea family            | Peas; broad, French and runner beans                                                   | B      |
| Cucumber family       | Cucumber, courgette, pumpkin, butternut squash                                         | B      |
| Cabbage family        | Broccoli, cabbage, cauliflower, kale, sprouts, radish, turnip, swede, rocket, pak choi | C      |
| Onion group (alliums) | Onion, garlic, leek, spring onion, shallot, chives                                     | D      |
| Carrot family         | Carrot, parsnip, celery, celeriac, parsley, dill, coriander                            | D      |
| Beet family           | Beetroot, chard, true spinach                                                          | D      |
| Daisy family          | Lettuce, chicory, endive                                                               | D      |
| Grass family          | Sweetcorn                                                                              | B      |

\*Letters refer to the example on page 2. B and D combine different families in separate patches; they are planning groups, not botanical families. Choose the crops you actually grow. [R1, R2]

### Two easy mistakes to avoid

Radish and turnip belong with brassicas, even though you harvest their roots. Potatoes and tomatoes share a family, even though one grows below ground and the other above it.

Keep established perennial crops, such as asparagus, rhubarb and chives, in permanent positions. Record annual herbs in the rotation; basil belongs to the mint family and can occupy a separate annual herb patch.

CROP ROTATION / PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

# A plan for your plot.

A flexible four-year example, plus advice for smaller spaces

Divide your annual growing area into four sections. Keep the families assigned to each group together as the groups move; within a mixed group, give each crop its own space. This example is a layout aid, not a required feeding sequence.

| YEAR | BED 1 | BED 2 | BED 3 | BED 4 |
|------|-------|-------|-------|-------|
| 1    | A     | B     | C     | D     |
| 2    | B     | C     | D     | A     |
| 3    | C     | D     | A     | B     |
| 4    | D     | A     | B     | C     |

A Potato family · B Peas/beans, cucurbits and sweetcorn  
C Brassicas · D Alliums, carrots/related crops, beets and lettuce

## Beds & allotments

Draw a map each season and record catch crops, overwintered crops and problems. Keep mustard green manure in the brassica group. Feed for the crop and soil condition; peas and beans do not provide a complete fertiliser programme. [R1, R2]

## Pots & grow bags

Changing a pot's position does not change its compost history. For repeated tomatoes or potatoes, use clean containers and fresh suitable peat-free compost. Keep suspect compost away from susceptible crops. [R5]

## Raised beds & small plots

Use named sections if whole beds are impractical. A tiny move within shared soil gives limited separation. If the full cycle will not fit, avoid repeating susceptible families where possible and use pots to add space.

## The UK winter

A winter leek or kale crop still occupies its group until cleared. Do not force a change on 1 January. Plan from actual harvests, and avoid working soil when waterlogged; wet ground is easily compacted. [R2]

### When rotation is not enough

Clubroot and allium white rot can survive much longer than four years. If either is suspected, identify the problem before replanting, avoid moving affected soil and get disease-specific advice. A routine rotation is not a cure. [R3, R4]

Sources checked / [R1] Garden Organic – Planning your planting · [R2] University of Minnesota – Healthy garden soil · [R3] AHDB – Clubroot and cropping · [R4] AHDB – Allium white rot research · [R5] Garden Organic – Container growing